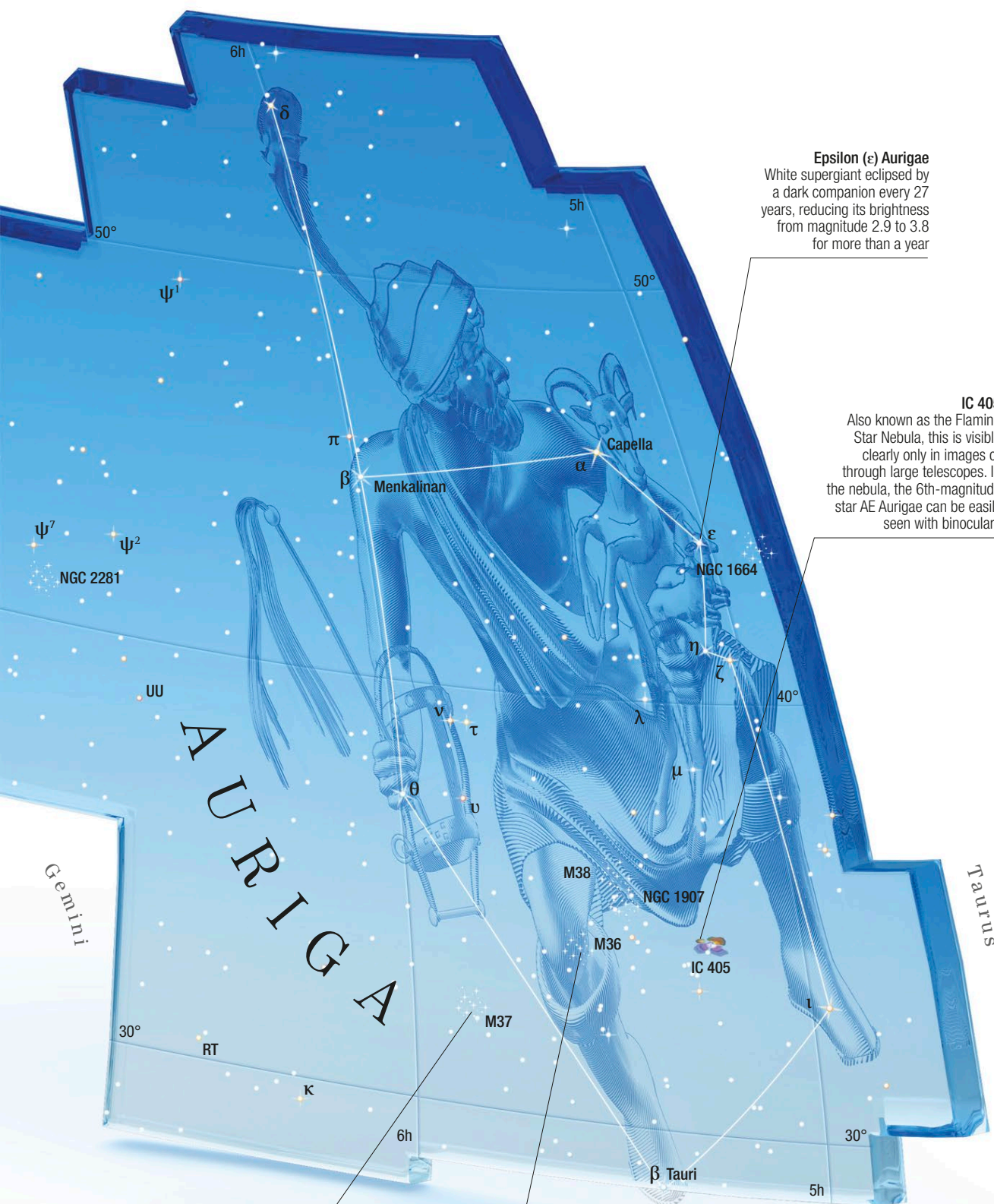




Epsilon (ε) Aurigae
White supergiant eclipsed by a dark companion every 27 years, reducing its brightness from magnitude 2.9 to 3.8 for more than a year

IC 405
Also known as the Flaming Star Nebula, this is visible clearly only in images or through large telescopes. In the nebula, the 6th-magnitude star AE Aurigae can be easily seen with binoculars

M37
The largest and richest of the three Messier star clusters in Auriga; it contains several hundred stars but all are faint

M36
The smallest of the chain of three Messier star clusters in Auriga but the easiest to spot; it contains about 60 stars



< IC 405
The hot, blue star at the left of this image, called AE Aurigae, was ejected from the region of the Orion Nebula about three million years ago. It has now reached this nebula in Auriga. As the star is passing through, it is lighting up the nebula spectacularly, giving rise to its popular name of the Flaming Star Nebula. Eventually, the star will move on and the nebula will darken.

KEY DATA

Size ranking 21
Brightest stars Capella (α) 0.1, Menkalinan (β) 1.9
Genitive Aurigae
Abbreviation Aur
Highest in sky at 10pm December–February
Fully visible 90°N–30°S

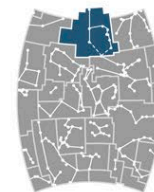


CHART 6

MAIN STARS

Capella Alpha (α) Aurigae
Binary of yellow and orange giants
☼ 0.1 ↔ 43 light-years

Menkalinan Beta (β) Aurigae
Blue-white subgiant or main-sequence star
☼ 1.9 ↔ 81 light-years

Epsilon (ε) Aurigae
White supergiant
☼ 3.0 ↔ 2,000 light-years

Zeta (ζ) Aurigae
Orange giant
☼ 3.8 ↔ 790 light-years

Eta (η) Aurigae
Blue-white main-sequence star
☼ 3.2 ↔ 243 light-years

Theta (θ) Aurigae
Blue-white main-sequence star
☼ 2.6 ↔ 165 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

M36
Open cluster

M37
Open cluster

M38
Open cluster

NGC 1664
Open cluster

NGC 2281
Open cluster

IC 405 (Flaming Star Nebula)
Emission and reflection nebula